

MADRAS MASTERPIECES 1. 'He and Prison' by S.G. Vasudev 2. 'The Sentinel' by D.P. Roy Chowdhury 3. 'Muria Maiden' by J. Sultan Ali 4. Untitled by R.B. Bhaskaran 5. Untitled by K.C.S. Paniker 6. Untitled by V. Viswanandhan 7. Untitled by L. Munuswamy 8. 'Bird' by S. Nandagopal 9. 'Dark Mirror (Triptych)' by C. Douglas

L. Munuswamy's abstract paintings are among the more straightforwardly hypnotic works on display as part of *Madras Modern: Regionalism and Identity*, at Delhi's DAG (on till July 6). Two works in particular—'Elephants' (1959) and 'Fashion' (1963)—show us Munuswamy's singular grasp of line and space. The latter has a very Willem de Kooning colour palette. The female figure that emerges in 'Fashion' amidst the visual density and the text running horizontally and vertically, has a curiously contrived quality to it, the fashion industry's idealised vision of a consumer object. Even if we overlook the de Kooning influence, it's clear that Munuswamy's work represents modernity in full bloom in the Madras school.

The exhibition brings together the works of K.C.S. Paniker, Debi Prasad Roy Chowdhury, J. Sultan Ali, S. Dhanapal, R.B. Bhaskaran, S. Nandagopal et al. Curator Ashrafi S. Bhagat's accompanying, eponymous exhibition book contextualises the Madras Art Movement, a "late phenomenon of modernity in South India within the national context". This is the second edition of the show, after the inaugural edition in Mumbai in 2019.

Kishore Singh, head of exhibitions and publications at DAG, says, "We have done exhibitions around collectives and genres before; we had one on the Bengal School, the Progressive Artists' Group, on Santiniketan and so on. We wanted to cover the Madras Art Movement, which was actually the last thrust of modernism before contemporary art took over. Even though the art school in Madras (now Chennai) is the oldest in the country, we found that representation of artists from the southern regions wasn't quite up to the mark in places like Delhi and Mumbai."

The Government College of Fine Arts (then called the Madras School of Art) was the epicentre of the movement and the exhibition pays special attention to its artist-principals like Chowdhury (tenure 1929-1957), Paniker, Munuswamy, Dhanapal and so on.

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We see how the trend moved from figurative or pattern-based works to greater and greater degrees of abstraction. We also learn how the Madras artists learned to incorporate a sense of Indian-ness in these works. Several paintings on display in *Madras Modern* draw from Hindu iconography, including tantric traditions. Others involve text derived from south Indian languages (Paniker's abstract works sometimes use a deliberately illegible version of Malayalam, for example).

It's also instructive to note the differences in the tenures of the British principals vis-à-vis the Indian artist-principals that followed (Roy Chowdhury was the first). For instance, under E.B. Havell, who had previously headed the Government School of Art, Calcutta, the Madras school began to emphasise crafts over arts.

Under Paniker's stewardship, the project of modernity began in real earnest. An unconventional thinker and artist, Paniker's early days at the helm of the Madras school were marked by differences in opinion with the outgoing principal, the sculptor-painter D.P. Roy Chowdhury who was also one of Paniker's own teachers. Slowly and steadily, however, Paniker's efforts bore fruit and eventually in 1966, he alongside his students and colleagues formed the Cholamandal Artists' Village, 9 km from Chennai.